

Introduction

Open source software is a all engaging term for a wide range of approaches to designing, licencing and selling software. There is no specific definition of what open source software is or is *not*, but by and large, the Debian Free Software Guidelines apply. *Open source* in common usage is pretty recent, something that was absent in its present form before the turn of the century. Both licenced and free software were released with their source code prior to that, and there were a number of other models – such as paying extra for the source of a software after buying it, buying just the source of the software, or the source being given for free to anyone who purchased the software. All of this could technically mean open source as the source code of a particular software is available to anyone who wants it, but that is not what open source means in common usage.

Open source software, as it is commonly understood, involves the process of the development of the software as well. The development schedule of the software, and the feature list is decided by online collaboration of people working for the projects. The bugs in the software are tracked by a community of testers, and their recommendations are taken seriously. Some software and flavours of Linux are in such active developments, that the current alpha versions of these often incorporate suggestions and fixes days after they are suggested. Once a software is released, depending on the licence, open source generally allows you to go ahead and do what you want with it. What does all of this mean to the lay user?

The way open source enthusiasts look at it, it is immaterial whether everyone actually takes apart the source, but the freedom to do so, is something that is vital to how computers are used. If you're investing in all the pieces of hardware that makes up a computer, you should have the freedom to use that particular hardware in any way you feel fit, instead of the ways instead of a few corporations deciding for you. To an open source enthusiast, such a freedom is a very fundamental one, and should be enshrined in the constitution if possible. All of this is still